Handloom and Textiles of India

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Introduction to Indian Handloom and Textiles

India has one of the oldest and richest textile traditions in the world. Cotton was grown and woven in the Indus Valley more than 4,500 years ago, and Indian cloth such as the fine muslin of Bengal, calico and chintz was exported to Rome, Southeast Asia and Europe. A handloom is a hand-operated loom on which cloth is woven by a weaver, without the use of electricity, in contrast to powerlooms and mills. The handloom sector is the second-largest source of employment in rural India after agriculture, with about 35 lakh (3.5 million) people engaged in weaving and allied work, and many are women. India produces most of the world's handwoven fabric. Each handloom textile is unique and reflects the culture, climate, materials and skills of its region. Handloom products are eco-friendly because they use little energy. The government's Handloom Mark and the Geographical Indication (GI) tags help to identify genuine products, and the Handloom (Reservation of Articles for Production) Act, 1985 reserves some products for handloom weavers.

The Textile Tradition and Freedom Movement

Cotton and silk weaving shaped India's economy. Under British rule, cheap mill-made cloth from England hurt Indian weavers. Mahatma Gandhi promoted khadi, hand-spun and handwoven cloth, and the charkha (spinning wheel), as symbols of self-reliance, and the Swadeshi Movement, which began on 7 August 1905 against the partition of Bengal, called for boycotting foreign cloth. The spinning wheel appeared on the Indian flag before the Ashoka Chakra.

When Is National Handloom Day?

National Handloom Day is observed on 7 August every year. The date commemorates the Swadeshi Movement, launched on 7 August 1905 at the Calcutta Town Hall, which encouraged the use of Indian-made goods and boycotting of foreign goods and helped revive handloom weaving. The Government of India declared 7 August as National Handloom Day in 2015, and the first National Handloom Day was held on 7 August 2015 in Chennai at the Centenary Auditorium of the University of Madras, inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The day aims to honour weavers, raise awareness and promote handloom products, and the Ministry of Textiles holds exhibitions and gives awards, such as the Sant Kabir Award and the National Handloom Award. Tamil Nadu celebrates it with exhibitions by the Co-optex, the state's handloom cooperative society.

What Is Kanchipuram Silk Known For?

Kanchipuram silk, also called Kanjeevaram silk, comes from the temple town of Kanchipuram in Tamil Nadu and is among the most famous silks in the world. Kanjeevaram sarees are known for their lustre, durability, richness and weight. They are woven from pure mulberry silk yarn, usually brought from Karnataka, with zari, a thread of silver coated with gold, used in rich borders and pallus. A typical Kanjeevaram saree has a body and a contrasting border in bright colours, with traditional motifs, including temple towers (gopuram), peacocks, parrots, mangoes (mango motif), lotuses, checks, stripes and scenes from mythology. The weaving technique includes a special "korvai" or interlocking method in which the body and borders are woven separately and joined strongly, so that the join is firm. A single saree can take 10 days to a month to weave, depending on the design, and may weigh over a kilogram. These sarees are worn at weddings and festivals across South India, and a Kanjeevaram is often a bride's first choice. According to legend, the weavers are descendants of the sage Markandeya, who wove cloth for the gods, and most weavers belong to the Devanga and Saliyar communities. Kanchipuram silk got a Geographical Indication tag in 2005 to 2006, which requires the real sarees to have the zari with a minimum of silver and a specific amount of gold. A "Silk Mark" certifies purity. Weaving clusters are also found at Arani, Thirubuvanam near Kumbakonam, Salem and Kumbakonam in Tamil Nadu, and Tamil Nadu also is known for cotton handlooms such as Kovai cotton, Madurai Sungudi and Chettinad cotton, and Kancheepuram's silk-cotton.

Name Three Famous Indian Sarees

Three famous Indian sarees are Banarasi, Kanjeevaram and Paithani. Banarasi sarees from Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh are known for their gold and silver brocade, Mughal-inspired floral and foliate patterns and opulent weaving. Kanjeevaram sarees come from Tamil Nadu. Paithani sarees from Paithan in Maharashtra are known for their peacock and lotus motifs and for their borders with an oblique square design, woven in silk and zari. Other well-known sarees include Patola of Patan in Gujarat, woven with double-ikat technique; Bandhani of Gujarat and Rajasthan, tie-dye; Chanderi and Maheshwari of Madhya Pradesh; Pochampally ikat of Telangana; Mysore silk of Karnataka; Kasavu saree of Kerala, white with golden border, worn at Onam; Baluchari and Tant of West Bengal; Kantha stitch; Muga silk of Assam, which is naturally golden; Sambalpuri ikat of Odisha; Venkatagiri of Andhra Pradesh and Dharmavaram silk.

Other Textile Traditions

India's textile heritage includes Kalamkari, hand-painted or block-printed cotton from Andhra Pradesh, with the Srikalahasti style, block printing in Rajasthan (Bagru and Sanganer), Ajrakh in Kutch, Kashmiri pashmina shawls and carpets, Phulkari embroidery of Punjab, Chikankari of Lucknow and Zardozi embroidery. Khadi is hand-spun cotton woven by hand. The Tiruppur cluster in Tamil Nadu makes knitwear for the world, and Coimbatore is known as the "Manchester of South India" for its cotton mills.

Challenges Facing Handloom Weavers

Weavers face competition from cheaper powerloom imitations, rising raw material costs, low wages, lack of marketing, fewer young people in the profession, and health problems. Initiatives such as the National Handloom Development Programme, India Handloom Brand, online sales through platforms and e-commerce, and consumer awareness have helped. Buying direct from cooperatives such as Co-optex and ethical fashion brands supports weavers.

Future

The future of handloom lies in combining tradition with new designs, sustainable and natural dyes, slow fashion and international markets. Young designers are reviving weaves and promoting them, and the National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT) has a campus in Chennai.

Quick Facts

- Kanchipuram silk is known for pure mulberry silk with zari borders, durability, richness and temple motifs.
- National Handloom Day is observed on 7 August; the first was held in Chennai in 2015.
- Three famous sarees are Banarasi, Kanjeevaram and Paithani; others include Patola, Chanderi and Pochampally.
- The date commemorates the Swadeshi Movement of 7 August 1905.
- About 35 lakh people work in India's handloom sector.